miracles like making it rain or healing the sick, so it was not confined to the disbursement of charity. He wanted both to better the lives of individual supplicants and improve the very system in which they lived.

Thus, when Akbar celebrated Nauroz for the first time in 1582, he not only had the palace decorated with gold-embroidered cloth and ‘varieties of jewels’, ordered his amirs to organize parties, and present their emperor with offerings, and had the ‘lock . . . taken off’ the imperial treasury and money distributed to the poor, he also conducted a brainstorming session for the betterment of his realm.[27]

Abul Fazl lists the suggestions that were made. Akbar’s milk brother Aziz, for example, said that no one except the emperor should be allowed to order an execution. Quite possibly, the outspoken amir was making a subtle reference to how he had been under a cloud, just two years earlier, when Akbar appeared to disapprove of Aziz executing a mansabdar. Back in favour after his successes against the rebels in Bengal, Aziz may have been trying to convey his submission to his friend and emperor as well as his blunt manner allowed. Akbar’s son Salim, on the verge of his teens, declared that no one under twelve be allowed to marry, an idea he may have received from his father, whose Happy Sayings include a clear disapproval of child marriage.

The others, too, would have hoped to please, even flatter, Akbar, as instinctively as executives hope to please and flatter their CEOs. If, then, his amirs were trying to match Akbar’s own inclinations, it is worth noting how many of their suggestions concerned the public good. Todar Mal wanted to regularize charity, suggesting a new law that mandated the empire’s rich to ‘have a care of the empty-handed’. Qasim Khan wanted more sarais and Abul Fath a hospital. Faizi, Abul Fazl’s brother and Akbar’s favourite poet, hoped that ‘experienced and sympathetic persons might be appointed’ to fix the prices of goods across markets.[28]

It is worth noting, too, that Akbar’s very first order of business, after Nauroz, was to introduce a series of land and revenue reforms, as formulated by the lone surviving member of his triumvirate of accountants – Todar Mal. As much as these new measures aimed to increase cultivation, and thus imperial revenue, they were clearly informed by concern for the cultivators, too. There were twelve ordinances in all, the first of which